HAMASPIK LEOVDEI HASHEM

Can You Trust Hashem for Luxuries? Bitahon for Non-Essential Matters

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Sefer: HaMaspik L'Ovdei Hashem — Rabbeinu Avraham ben HaRambam (Rav Dana's Hebrew edition) **Chapter:** 8 — Bitachon and Reliance **Topic:** Employing bitachon for non-essential matters — Category 4 (important but non-essential) and Category 5 (luxuries) — and the beginning of the final section: the four levels of bitachon

Schedule note: This is the penultimate HaMaspik shiur until Elul. Next Monday b'ezrat Hashem we complete the levels of bitachon and summarise the whole chapter before the summer break. Shiurim continue as usual this week: Tuesday evening the Moreh, Thursday evening Halacha.

Recap — Where We Are in the Chapter

We are nearing the end of the longest chapter Rabbi Avraham wrote in this sefer. So far:

Section	Content
Definition	Bitachon defined; the different types of bitachon and the three attitudes toward hashgacha
Framework	Five main categories of employing bitachon (× physical and spiritual)
Category 1	Avoiding seriously harmful situations — in mundane and spiritual matters — correct to employ bitachon
Category 2	Avoiding minor harms — Rabbi Avraham holds it is **not** correct to employ bitachon; we saw the machloket Rishonim (vs. Rabbeinu Yonah on בכל דרכיך דעהו)
Category 3	Obtaining **essential** matters — certainly correct to employ bitachon for basic material needs, as Yaakov Avinu did

The two questions on Category 3 (from previous weeks):

1. **Q1:** Many verses state that Hakadosh Baruch Hu grants basic parnassah even to animals — so what is the practical need for bitachon? **Answer:** True for animals; but humans have free will, and our obedience or disobedience can broaden or cut off our basic parnassah.
2. **Q2:** Verses like **עיני כל אליך ישברו** imply that trusting in Hashem is *natural* for every creature — how does that fit verses that *praise* bitachon (אשרי אדם בוטח בך)? **Two answers:** (a) *kol* means *rov* — the majority either voluntarily choose bitachon or are compelled to it in difficult scenarios; (b) *kol* means literally *all* — everyone trusts in someone or something, and everything traces back to Hashem, so all are *indirectly* trusting in Him; the verses of praise speak of those who **consciously and voluntarily** choose bitachon.

Jobs and bitachon: Some occupations make bitachon easier (income open to chance/luck — e.g. self-employment), some harder (income fixed and dependent on other people — e.g. the personal assistant of a wealthy employer). But in **every** job, including total dependence on one employer, a person remains obligated to have bitachon — it is simply harder work.

Part 1: Category 4 — Important but Non-Essential Matters

1.1 The principle: yourself vs. your family

Rabbi Avraham's position, summarised before learning it inside:

- **For yourself** — strictly, a person should employ bitachon only for essential matters, not for non-essentials, even important ones.
- **For your family** — you can and **should** employ bitachon even for matters that are non-essential but important. What is "extra" for you is considered **essential** for your wife and children.

ומה שקרוב אל הנחיצות הוא כל הדרוש לאדם לפרנסת אשתו וטפו

Things needed for the support of your spouse and children may not be essential for you personally, but they are considered essential for them — and therefore it is correct, appropriate and *required* to employ bitachon for them.

ואילו ככל שהרחיב אדם את בני משק ביתו כגון עבדים ושפחות... וכל שמתרבה הרי הוא קרוב לנחוץ

But the more a person expands his household with things that are not essential, the more he borders on Category 5 — unnecessary luxuries.

1.2 Where is the line? It depends on the person

התחום שבין שני הקצוות גדול מאוד ומשתנה לפי מצבו השונה של היחיד

The territory between the two extremes (essential ↔ luxury) is vast, and it shifts according to each individual's situation.

כי מלך ישראל זקוק לדברים ששום נזיר מתבודד אינו זקוק להם

A king of Israel needs things no secluded hermit needs. Hence the provisions of **David and Shlomo** — their armies, horses and so on — were *close to necessary* despite their quantity. But if one of the servants of the righteous took an **extra** servant he could manage without, that acquisition would be for luxury.

1.3 The Shunamite woman — the model of self-limitation

When Elisha, grateful for her hospitality, offered: **היש לדבר לך אל המלך או אל שר הצבא** — "Shall I speak on your behalf to the king or the army commander?" — she answered:

בתוך עמי אנכי ישבת — "I dwell among my own people."

She limited herself to what was necessary; she needed no powerful political connections. And note her consistency: when travelling, though a donkey was saddled and walking with her to spare her the exertion, she told her attendant not to stop for her to ride **unless she said so** — she would not use even what was prepared, unless genuinely needed. A very high level — and it depends on each person.

1.4 Not everyone can live on dry bread — temperament and upbringing

ודע... שלא כל אדם יכול לסיבת מזגו והרגלו להסתפק באכילת פת חרבה ולבישת מלבוש גס

Not every person, by temperament (*mezeg*) and habit/upbringing (*hergel*), is able to satisfy himself with plain bread and coarse clothing.

אלא יש מי שמוכרח מחמת מזגו ומצבו לפת את פיתו בבשר וללבוש בגדים בינוניים ולדור בבית בינוני — כמעט כשם שאחרים צריכים פת חרבה ובגדי כותנה וצריף דל

For some people, bread with meat, average clothing and an average home are as *necessary* as dry bread and a poor hut are for others. What is technically non-essential can be, for that person, an essential.

Only Hakadosh Baruch Hu knows, deep down, what each — **ויבוא עליו היודע צרכיו של כל אדם** person truly needs, and — **והוא היודע אם פלוני מצמצם ומבקש ממנו רק את הדרוש לו או דברים מותרות**. He knows whether we are asking for what we require or for luxury.

1.5 The short Amida — "give each person according to their needs"

This is why Chazal instituted the abbreviated Amida (Gemara Berachot; still halachically applicable today in specific pressed circumstances):

צרכי עמך ישראל מרובין ודעתם קצרה — the needs of Your people are many, but their capacity to articulate them is short — **יהי רצון מלפניך ה' אלוהינו שתתן לכל אחד ואחד כדי פרנסתו ולכל גויה וגויה די מחסורה, והטוב בעיניך עשה**

Give each individual *according to his parnassah*, each body *what it lacks* — and do what is good in Your eyes. The tefillah itself acknowledges that "need" is defined per person, and Hashem is the one who knows the true measure.

1.6 Rabbi Kada's application: nowadays

The Rabbi argued that in the society and civilisation we live in today, even things beyond the bare basics have become, for us, close to essential: a decent home, a decent car, decent clothes. Given the world we live in and the upbringing we have had, it is reasonable today to ask Hashem for these, to employ bitachon for these — even though strictly speaking they are non-essential. One might argue: "No — spend your time learning Torah, satisfy yourself with the most basic home, everyone sleeping in one room; you have shelter, clothes and bread." Rabbi Avraham's framework says otherwise: we may **work** for these things, **pray** for these things, and **have bitachon** for these things —

ובלבד שיתלה לבו במבטח השם יתעלה ובצד השתדלותו

— provided the heart hangs its trust on Hashem alongside the hishtadlut.

1.7 Yaakov Avinu — the proof case, in two phases

Phase 1 — alone: Fleeing from Esav, before he had wives or children, Yaakov asked only for essentials:

ונתן לי לחם לאכול ובגד ללבוש — bread to eat and clothing to wear. Bare basics.

Phase 2 — as head of a household: With wives and children, he sought a broader, better parnassah:

When shall I also provide for my own house?" (his words to Lavan: I" — **מתי אעשה גם אנכי לביתי** must stop working for you and build for my family — *more* than the basics.)

And Hashem helped him because he trusted: והשם יתעלה סייעו בזכות שבטח בו — even though he toiled shepherding Lavan's flocks, and even though Lavan schemed to defraud him (**ותחלף את משכרתי עשרת מונים** — "you changed my wages ten times"), and even though Yaakov engaged in the whole strategy of the rods (המקלות) in Parashat Vayetzei so the flocks would bear according to his wage-terms — **with all that, he acknowledged** that everything he attained came from Hashem's help, not from his own devices:

".G-d has taken your father's livestock and given it to me" — **ויצל אלוהים את מקנה אביכם ויתן לי**

And Rachel and Leah acknowledged the same:

all this wealth was destined from — **כי כל העושר אשר הציל אלוהים מאבינו — לנו הוא ולבנינו** .Hashem

The conclusion Rabbi Avraham draws: even when engaged in obtaining things beyond bare necessity, **חייב אדם להישען על השם יתעלה ועל סיבותיו** — a person must lean on Hashem and His causes; the occupation of Torah-keepers must remain bound up with bitachon even in our own days — **שהביטחון קודם לעיסוק והלב תלוי... בעילת העילות ובסיבת הסיבות** — the bitachon precedes the work, and the heart stays suspended on the Cause of all causes.

1.8 The Rabbi's important aside: do not impose your chumrot on your family

Even if you personally are on a level of chasidut/piety and wish to hold yourself to the strict standard (essentials only), that is lovely — **for yourself**. You cannot impose your stringencies on people who have not chosen them, **especially your spouse and children**. This is the general Torah approach to chumrot: take on whatever you want for yourself; do not impose it on others. For your dependents, anything beyond the bare necessities is treated as essential — you must work for it and employ bitachon for it.

Part 2: Category 5 — Luxuries

2.1 The principle: do not ask, do not lift your eyes

ולא ישאל ולא ישא עיניו לשום דבר שאינו בגדר ההכרח או בקרבתו

A person should not ask — not even *pray* — and should not employ bitachon for anything outside the domain of the necessary or what borders on it.

ואם השיג את מבוקשו יסתפק בו ולא יצטרך לשאר דברים

And once he has obtained what he needs — be satisfied; stop asking.

2.2 The examples (and the modern translations)

Food: Granted, today we cannot be expected to eat bare bread and salt daily; nice evening meals, bread, fruit, vegetables — appropriate. **But: ואינו חייב להשתמש במיני בשרים מיוחדים להתקין מהם מטעמים כטעמי המלך** — even if you have the financial ability, you should not be *asking Hashem* for the finest steaks every night like the delicacies of a king.

Note: This is *not* a discussion of perishut (abstinence) — that is a separate topic coming later in the sefer. If Hashem blessed you with means and you choose to enjoy them, that is fine *from this perspective*. The point is narrower: it is inappropriate to **ask** for, and place **bitachon** on, pure luxury.

Clothing: וניטל ללבוש מעיל צמר בחורף ובגד פשתן בקיץ — a wool coat in winter, linen in summer: understandable; today one needs to dress respectably and presentably. **But not: פרוות סנאים מרוקמת משי** — squirrel fur embroidered with silk — **או פשתן דקה או בגד שרב אלכסנדרי בקיץ** — fine linen or an Alexandrian *sharav* garment. *(A participant suggested "sharav" here may mean an elaborate, very expensive scarf.)* Designer everything — don't ask for it.

Transport: ואינו חייב לרכב על פרד יקר או סוס אציל חבוש אוכף מפואר ומלא אבני חן ועטור רסן תפארת — no need for a costly mule or a noble horse with a magnificent gem-studded saddle and a glorious bridle — i.e., in our terms, the most beautiful luxury car. A decent, presentable car — understandable.

Family: Clothing your wife and children respectably, even somewhat generously — understandable (that's Category 4). **But: ואינו חייב לקשט אשתו בעדי עדיים ולהלבישה משי וכתונת פסים... גם כן לבנותיו** — not to adorn them in finery, silk and striped robes.

Household help: If you need a servant to serve you and your children — fine. **ואינו חייב להשכיר כמה וכמה עבדים... אם אפשר בלעדיהם** — but not many servants when you can manage without them.

2.3 Why luxury-bitachon fails — and whose fault it is

כמו שאמר שלמה: אשר עשה האלקים את האדם ישר והמה בקשו חשבונות רבים

Hashem made man straight — but people seek out many calculations (justifications).

The person who **ישליך יהבו על השגת המותרות** — casts his hope on obtaining these luxuries — then **ישתומם על שאין ביטחונו מוצא פרי** — is astonished that his bitachon bears no fruit. "I prayed every day to win the lottery and buy a house on Billionaire's Row — and I had *true* bitachon!" It is not going to happen; why should you have the audacity to ask for such a thing?

The Rambam in the Moreh says similarly: the desire for luxuries has no end (*ein ladavar sof*). Necessities can be budgeted — electricity, gas, tax, food: there is a limit. Luxuries have no limit: if I attain silver cutlery I will want gold; if gold, then crystal. **וכן כל בור שמחשבתו נפסדת** — every fool of corrupted thinking **אינו חדל לסבול הצער** — never stops suffering the pain that he hasn't attained what others have. Why does *he* have the best car and house and I don't? People even put themselves in real danger — **בהפלגה בים ועבודה בשדה** — perilous sea voyages, punishing labour — to get the extra thing; then complain against Hashem, curse their luck ("It's not fair — I work as hard, I'm observant, I trust as much!") —

> **עד כדי כך הגיע הדמיון... עד שחשבו הבורא לחוסר יכולת** — imagination goes so far that they attribute it to *inability* on the Creator's part: "I prayed, I had bitachon — Hashem must be *unable*."

Life does not work like that. They blame Hashem when really they should blame themselves.

2.4 The categories are person-relative: Hillel and *dei machsoro*

The Gemara in Ketubot: a wealthy man was accustomed to travel with servants running before him; he lost his money. Hillel held that the appropriate tzedaka for him was not merely food and

clothing but **servants to run before him** — because *that* is **די מחסורו** — "sufficient for his lack." Having grown up with it his whole life, for *him* it may be Category 3 — a bare necessity. But someone who did **not** grow up that way, who *puts himself* into dependence on such things — it is wrong to ask for them, wrong to have bitachon for them, and wrong to blame Hashem when they don't come.

"You can ask Hashem for anything"? We're told as children: ask Hashem for anything. No — ask Hashem for what's *necessary*, what you *need*, what's *important* in life.

The exception — l'shem Shamayim: If you genuinely mean it — "I want to open a Torah centre, a new school, a new kind of institution, because the education available isn't right" — for *that* it is appropriate to ask Hashem for the funds and the ability. As we said at the beginning of the chapter: for **things for Hashem**, you may always ask.

2.5 Objection: והתענג על ה׳ ויתן לך משאלות לבך

שמא תאמר — doesn't David say (Tehillim 37): "Delight in Hashem and He will give you the requests of your heart"? Doesn't *hit'aneg* (delight/oneg) imply the beyond-necessary?

Answer — read the whole Psalm: לא נתכוון דוד לבעל תאווה שיתמכר לתענוגות — David is not addressing the pleasure-seeker chasing luxuries. The Psalm *opens*:

אל תתחר במרעים אל תקנא בעושי עולה — do not compete with evildoers, do not envy the workers of iniquity —

Don't be jealous of the wicked's success. Why? It is all transient:

כי כחציר מהרה ימלו וכירק דשא יבולון — like grass they swiftly wither, like green herbage they fade.

Rather (v. 3): **בטח בה' ועשה טוב שכן ארץ ורעה אמונה** — trust in Hashem, do good, dwell *permanently*, shepherd faithfulness — play the long game. *Then* comes "delight in Hashem." Clearly, one who is not envying evildoers but trusting Hashem and nurturing his emunah **לא יבקש לו מותרות בחיים ומשאלות לבבו... בגדר ההכרח** — is not going to be requesting life's luxuries; — the "requests of his heart" are within the domain of the necessary.

And look to the end of the passage: גול על ה' דרכך ובטח עליו והוא יעשה. והוציא כאור צדקך ומשפטך כצהרים — *tzidkecha* is what is moderately, rightly yours; *mishpatecha* is the entitlement a person deserves — perhaps slightly more than the bare measure. Trust in Hashem and He gives you what you need, and maybe a bit beyond.

Two deeper readings of "delight":

והתענג על ה' — spiritual closeness, not physical things. **in Hashem** means delight.

ויתן לך משאלות לבך may refer to **השלמות האמיתית** — the true perfection — the request of David himself: **אחת שאלתי מאת ה' אותה אבקש, שבתי בבית ה' כל ימי חיי, לחזות בנועם ה' ולבקר בהיכלו.**

מאין ספק כי השם יתעלה נותן — And one who genuinely aspires to that closeness *receives* it as Chazal teach: **בא לטהר מסייעין אותו**, and on והתקדשתם והייתם קדושים: **אדם מקדש עצמו מעט — מקדשין אותו הרבה; מלמטה — מקדשין אותו מלמעלה.**

King Shlomo's dream is the proof: Hashem said **שאל מה אתן לך**. Shlomo asked for a heart that hears — wisdom. Hashem answered: **יען אשר שאלת את הדבר הזה ולא שאלת לך עושר... הנה עשיתי כדבריך** — *because* you asked for this and not for wealth, I give you the wisdom — **and also what you did not ask for**. When you don't ask for these things, Hashem may well give them to you.

2.6 A kal vachomer from the king

The Torah warns **even the king of Israel** — one of the 613 mitzvot — against excess:

לא ירבה לו סוסים... ולא ירבה לו נשים... וכסף וזהב לא ירבה לו מאד

Chazal set the limits (18 wives; a corresponding limit on horses). And a king *needs* horses for his armies, and his court is part of his royal role. **אם במלך... נאמר כך — קל וחומר לשאר בני אדם**: if the Torah says this of a king who genuinely requires provision, all the more so for the rest of us.

2.7 Objection: but the Avot were wealthy!

?doesn't the Torah say explicitly that the Avot amassed great wealth — **שמא תאמר**

- **Avraham: ואברהם כבד מאד במקנה בכסף ובזהב** — very heavy in livestock, silver and gold.
- **Yitzchak:** whatever he touched returned a hundredfold (invest £1, receive £100).
- **Yaakov:** enriched through the episode with Lavan — **כי כל העושר אשר הציל אלוהים מאבינו לנו הוא ולילדינו**.

Rabbi Avraham's answer — two parts:

1. **They needed it for their public role: האבות היו זקוקים לכך מפני שייסדו את האומה והיו עושים נפשות** — they founded the nation and were "making souls," drawing people close to Hashem: **את הנפש אשר עשו בחרן** by Avraham; and by Yaakov — **ויאמר יעקב לאחיו לקטו אבנים** (at the covenant with Lavan). Yaakov had no brothers with him — Esav was not there — so *echav* must mean his companions/students: **אחיו בדת, שמושכם אל הטוב ומחזקם**. Students turn to their teachers not only for Torah but also for material assistance; and — like it or not — wealth carries influence. Their wealth served the mission.
2. **They never asked for it: יתר על כן, האבות לא ביקשו להם אלא די הצורך** — the Torah itself testifies: Yaakov asked only **לחם לאכול ובגד ללבוש**. Rather, **השם יתעלה הגדיל חסדו עמהם והשפיע עליהם מרוב טובו אשר לא ביקשוה ולא כיוונו לה** — Hashem, from His abundant kindness, in the merit of their dedication and their bitachon, poured on them what they had not requested — exactly as with Shlomo: **וגם אשר לא שאלת נתתי לך, גם עושר גם כבוד**. And this was David's own prayer: **הט לבי אל עדותיך ואל אל בצע** — turn my heart to Your testimonies, not to profit — and worldly success came to him unbidden.

2.8 Closing the five categories

in short: one need not, and should not, aspire to — **ק"ץ מאמרנו: נאמר כי אין צורך לשאוף עליהם** luxuries; bitachon placed on such things is misplaced. The Torah-keeper who aspires to this .should not set his trust or his eyes upon them — **שלא ישים את מבטחו ואת עיניו בהם** elevated level

And the promise: it may well be that Hashem repays such a person beyond his requests — **יכול להיות שהשם יתעלה ישלם לו כגמולו... ויתרה עליו גמולים שאינם הכרחיים מצד חסדו וטובו** — as the Torah promises abundance, and as the navi says: **והריקותי לכם ברכה עד בלי די**. And Chazal expound: **מאי עד בלי די? עד שיבלו שפתותיכם מלומר די** — blessing until your lips wear out from saying "enough!" (The Rabbi: until you're saying — I have nowhere to put all these clothes, my driveway is too small for all these cars...)

Summary of the five categories:

Category	Employ bitachon?
1. Avoiding serious harm (physical & spiritual)	Yes — with all natural means
2. Avoiding minor harms	No (Rabbi Avraham; machloket Rishonim) — though for small *spiritual* matters, yes
3. Essentials (food, clothing, shelter)	Absolutely — ask and trust
4. Important non-essentials	For your dependents — yes, obligatory; for yourself — today, arguably yes, given our society and upbringing
5. Luxuries	Never — do not ask, do not trust for them, and do not be surprised when Hashem does not listen

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Part 3: The Final Section — The Levels of Bitachon (begun)

The remaining section of the chapter (to be completed next week): the **four levels of bitachon**, in ascending order.

3.1 Bitachon lives in the heart

וכל זאת עליך לדעת כי הביטוי "בטחון" כולל הרבה מדרגות, אף על פי שמובנה האמיתי של המילה מחייב שתהיה רק מדרגה אחת נקראת בטחון — colloquially we call all four levels "bitachon," though strictly only one (the third) is the true meaning. And lack of bitachon also has degrees.

ביאור הדבר: בטחון מסור ללב — bitachon is entrusted to the heart.

Seven weeks we have spent learning this chapter — the point is **וידעת היום והשבות אל לבבך**: knowledge must be brought down into the heart and into practical life. The verses consistently attach bitachon to the heart: **בו בטח לבי ונעזרתי**; **נכון לבו בטוח בה'**.

3.2 Two things that are NOT bitachon

1. **Despair. כל אימת שאין לב אדם בוטח בשם להשגת משאלתו** — a person who has given up hope of attaining his need ("I've lost my money and there's no hope from Hashem or anyone") — **אין אותו איש נקרא בוטח בשם**. This is corrupt thinking, turning away from the Creator's hashgacha. Against it: **קוה אל ה' חזק ויאמץ לבך וקוה אל ה'**; **יחל ישראל אל ה' מעתה ועד עולם**; **וקוה אל אלוהיך תמיד** — never give up hope; so long as you are doing your best, Hashem never abandons you.
2. **Trusting in flesh and blood instead of Hashem.** One who seeks his parnassah from a human being and rests his trust on him alone — "I trust only my employer" — without any mention of Hashem's help or seeing the human as merely His messenger: **ארור הגבר אשר יבטח באדם ושם בשר זרעו ומן ה' יסור לבו** — cursed.

Both of these are **מדרגות של חוסר ביטחון** — degrees of the *absence* of bitachon.

3.3 The four levels — levels 1 and 2 tonight

והנה מדרגות הביטחון הרי הן ארבע במספר

Level 1 — המיחל לחסד ה' (hoping for His kindness, while fearing one's sins):

שאדם מקווה ומצפה להשגת משאלתו מהשם יתעלה ברוב רחמיו, אף על פי שהוא חושש ודואג... שמא עוונותיו מונעים ממנו את הרחמים

A person genuinely trusts in his heart that everything comes from Hashem — but simultaneously worries it won't happen *for him*: not from lack of trust in Hashem, but "I don't deserve it; too much has gone wrong; my aveirot hold it back." This **is** a level of bitachon — a good level, the lowest — called **המיחל לחסד ה', המחכה ומקוה לרחמיו**, a *ba'al yirah v'tikvah*. David's verses encourage precisely this person: **חזקו ויאמץ לבבכם כל המיחלים לה'** — you're already there in trust; have more hope, more courage (and yes, stop sinning where relevant — but don't assume it always holds you back). And Hashem cherishes this person: **רוצה ה' את יראיו, את המיחלים לחסדו** — those who fear His punishment yet wait for His kindness even when they feel they have no merit.

Level 2 — trust plus active seeking (inner and spoken request):

מי שעל תקותו ותוחלתו מוסיף הבקשה לה' יתעלה — ביקוש פנימי שבלב וחיצוני שבלשון בתפילה

Everything in Level 1, but the trust is also *lived and expressed*: constant inner request and verbal tefillah — "Hashem, I know it all comes from You; this is the correct *mish'alot libi*, what I genuinely feel is necessary or important; please give it to me." As the Torah says explicitly (Va'etchanan): **ובקשתם משם את ה' אלקיך ומצאת כי תדרשנו בכל לבבך ובכל נפשך**. And many verses of David: **דרשו ה' ועזו בקשו פניו תמיד**; **לך אמר לבי בקשו פני, את פניך ה' אבקש**; **אליך ה' אקרא ואל ה' אתחנן**; **ודורשי ה' לא יחסרו כל טוב**; **בקשו את ה' כל ענוי הארץ**.

We should all be aiming for levels one and two.

Level 3 — begun (to be developed next week): certainty — חוסה בה':

מדרגה שלישית היא מעלת מי שבטוח בהשגת משאלתו מאת השם יתעלה ומאמין בזאת בוודאות בלי ספק

Not only trusting and praying, but **absolute confidence, without doubt**, that it will happen — the one who *takes refuge* in Hashem (**חוסה בה'**). Rabbi Avraham holds this is the *true* meaning of the word bitachon — a very high level.

The Rabbi Yisrael Salanter lottery story: A man told the Rabbi: "I've entered the lottery for £50,000 every week for years with full bitachon in Hashem — and never won." The Rabbi offered: "Let me give you £5,000 right now." — "Yes, absolutely!" — "Then I'm not giving you a penny. If you had *full* bitachon that you need — and will receive — fifty thousand, why on earth would you take five?" That is Level 3: full certainty. *(And the Rabbi added a second answer from tonight's learning: why are you employing bitachon for a lottery win at all? It's beyond the necessary — Category 5.)*

Level 4 — an extremely high level, almost impossible, perhaps beyond bitachon itself — will be presented next week, followed by a summary of the entire chapter.

Summary

- **Category 4 (important non-essentials):** For your dependents, the beyond-basic is *essential* — employ bitachon and work for it, as Yaakov did (**מתי אעשה גם אנכי לביתי**), while attributing all success to Hashem (**ויצל אלוהים את מקנה אביכם**). For yourself, the strict standard is basics — but need is person-relative (**מזג והרגל**; king vs. hermit; Hillel and *dei machsoro*), and in today's world the Rabbi argued most of us may legitimately ask for the decent home, car

and clothes our society renders near-essential. Never impose your personal stringencies on your family.

- **Category 5 (luxuries):** Do not ask, do not lift your eyes, do not place bitachon — designer clothes, the jewelled saddle (the luxury car), the staff of many servants. Luxury has no end (silver → gold → crystal); the one who trusts for it ends up blaming Hashem, even deeming Him "unable." Exception: genuine l'shem Shamayim dreams (building Torah institutions). **והתענג על ה'** read in context (Tehillim 37) promises spiritual delight and what is rightly yours — not luxuries; Shlomo received wealth precisely because he didn't ask. The Avot's wealth served their public mission and came unrequested, from Hashem's chesed. Ask only for the basics — and Hashem may bless **עד בלי די**.
- **Levels of bitachon (begun):** Not-bitachon = despair, or trust in flesh and blood. Level 1: heartfelt trust while fearing one's sins disqualify him — Hashem loves this person (**רוצה ה' את יראיו את המיחלים לחסדו**). Level 2: adds constant inner and verbal seeking (**ובקשתם משם**). Level 3 (the true "bitachon," begun): certainty without doubt — **חוסה בה'** — the Salanter lottery test. Level 4 next week.

Coming Up

Next Monday — the final HaMaspik shiur before the break: completing Level 3 (including bitachon in the geulah / end of days), Level 4, and a summary of the whole of Chapter 8, before resuming b'ezrat Hashem in Elul. This week as usual: **Tuesday** — Moreh Nebuchim; **Thursday** — Halacha.

B'Ezrat Hashem

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